

Quick Guide on pysimplemask

pysimplemask is an interactive tool for mask and q-map creation, specifically designed to help users identify and remove bad pixels or regions in their data. This guide walks you through installation and basic usage.

Installation

pysimplemask can be installed via pip. Before proceeding, ensure that you have *conda*, *miniconda*, or *miniforge* installed. If not, refer to the [Conda installation guide](#).

It is recommended to install pysimplemask in a dedicated conda environment to avoid conflicts:

```
pip install git+https://github.com/AdvancedPhotonSource/pySimpleMask
```

Alternatively, you can clone and install the package manually:

```
git clone https://github.com/AdvancedPhotonSource/pySimpleMask.git
cd pySimpleMask
pip install .
```

You may also obtain the latest single-file package (.whl) from your beamline contact:

```
pip install path_to_pysimplemask.whl
```

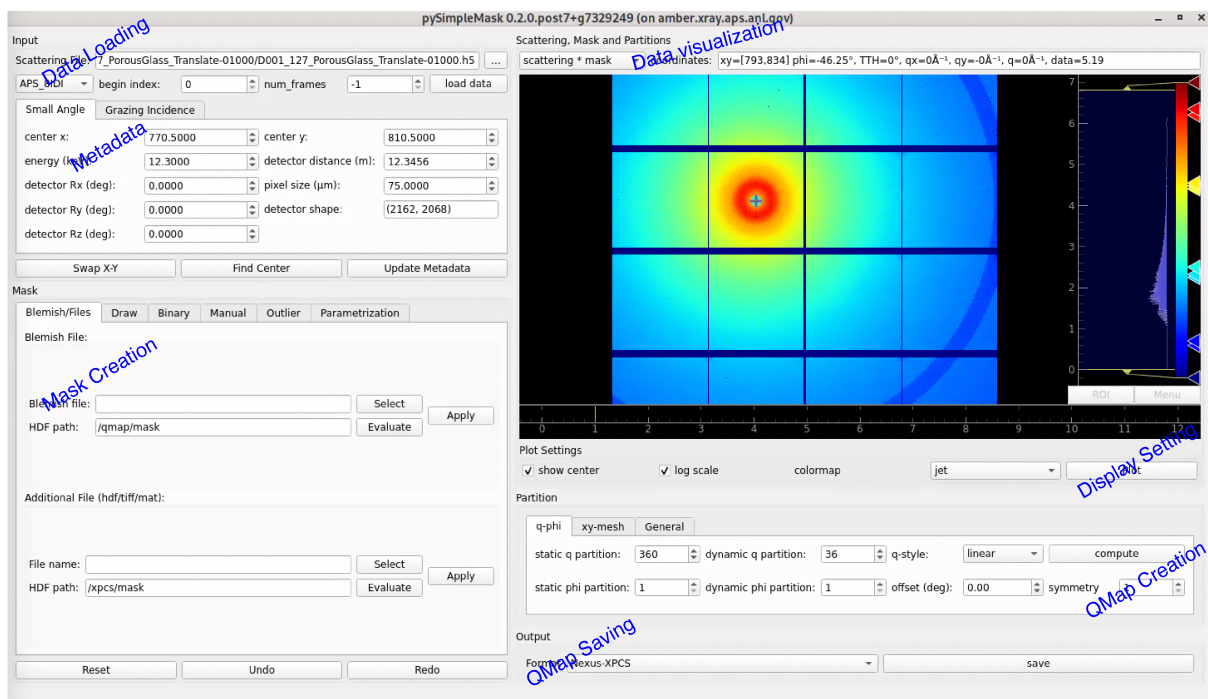
Start the Application

To launch pysimplemask, activate the environment where it was installed and run:

```
pysimplemask
pysimplemask --path PATH_TO_YOUR_DATA_FOLDER
```

Overview of the GUI Application

The GUI application is designed to be user-friendly with a clear layout



Typical Workflow

A typical workflow with pysimplemask includes:

1. **Select Beamline:** Choose the correct beamline preset.
2. **Load Data:** Navigate to and load the raw data file.
3. **Check Metadata:** Ensure metadata is correct and complete.
4. **Draw Mask:** Mask out bad regions (e.g., beamstops, streaks).
5. **Compute q-map:** Generate q-map based on scattering geometry.
6. **Save Results:** Export your mask and q-map for analysis.

Loading Data

After launching, select your beamline. For example, for XPCS at APS-8IDI, choose APS_8IDI.

Next, select the appropriate raw data file (not the metadata file ending with `_result.hdf`).

Detector Reference Table:

Detector	Mode	Filename Pattern
Eiger4M	fast	xxxxxxx.h5
Rigaku3M	fast	xxxxxxx.bin.XYZ
Rigaku3M	slow	xxxxxxx.h5
Rigaku500k	fast	xxxxxxx.bin

For Rigaku3M (slow mode), select only `.bin.000` — the remaining `.bin.XYZ` files will be loaded automatically.

You may control the number of frames to load using the `num_frames` setting:

num_frames	Frames Loaded
-1	<code>max(1000, total_frames // 5)</code> (default)

0	All frames
N > 0	[start_index : start_index + N]

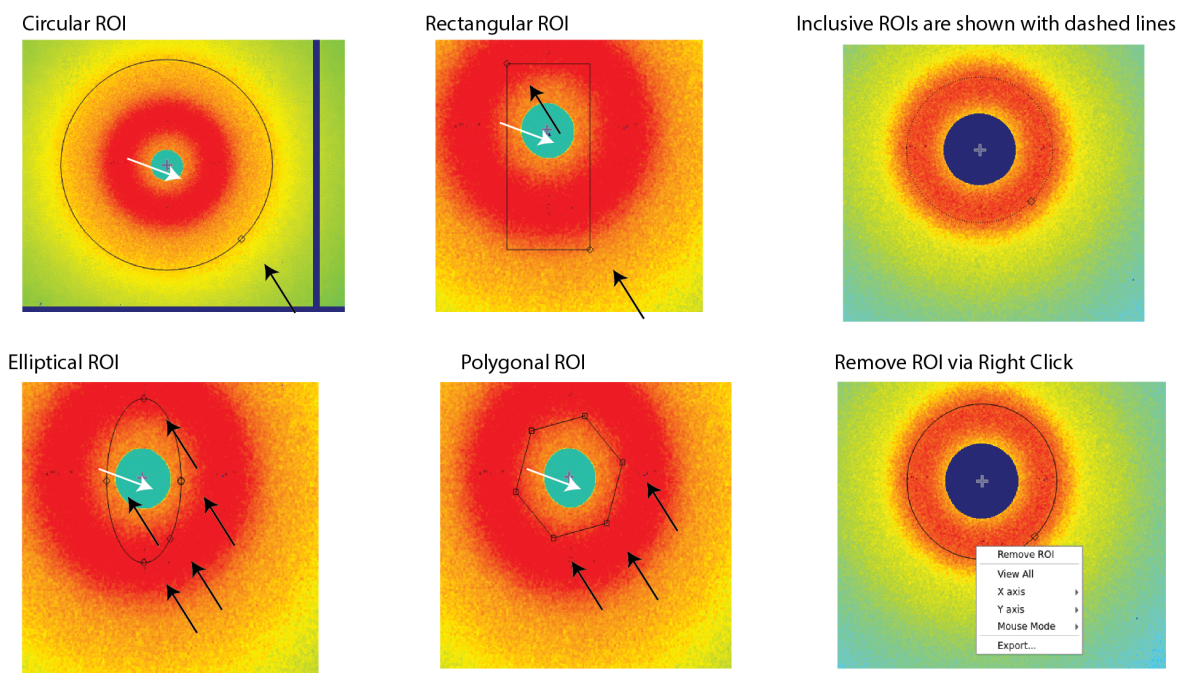
Drawing Masks

Once the data is loaded, you can begin defining masks to exclude bad pixels. XPCS analysis is highly sensitive to pixel artifacts, such as:

- Dead or hot pixels
- Saturated pixels
- Pixels obscured by beamstops, holders, or debris
- Scattering streaks from crystalline samples

Available masking methods include:

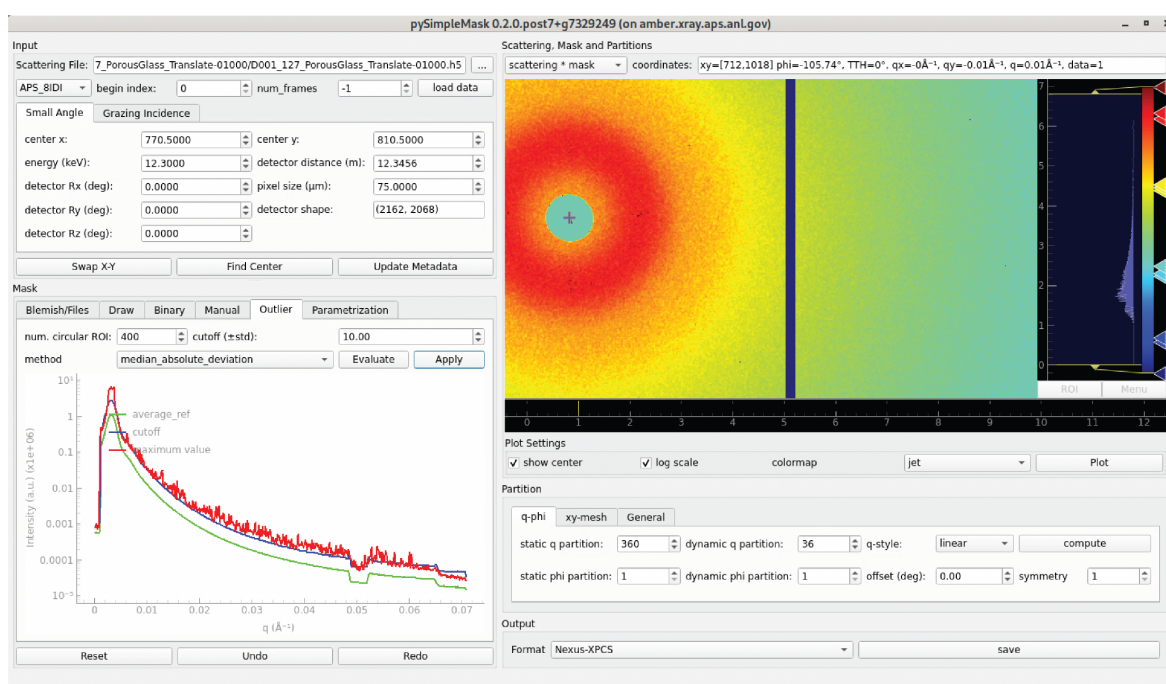
1. **Blemish Files:** Load predefined blemish files from `~/Documents/areaDetectorBlemish/` (available on APS Linux machines). These are automatically detected by `pysimplemask`. You may load the mask defined in your earlier QMap file by select the file and set the HDF path to `/qmap/mask`.
2. **Manual Drawing:** Use drawing tools (rectangle, ellipse, polygon) to define custom masks. You can include or exclude regions interactively.



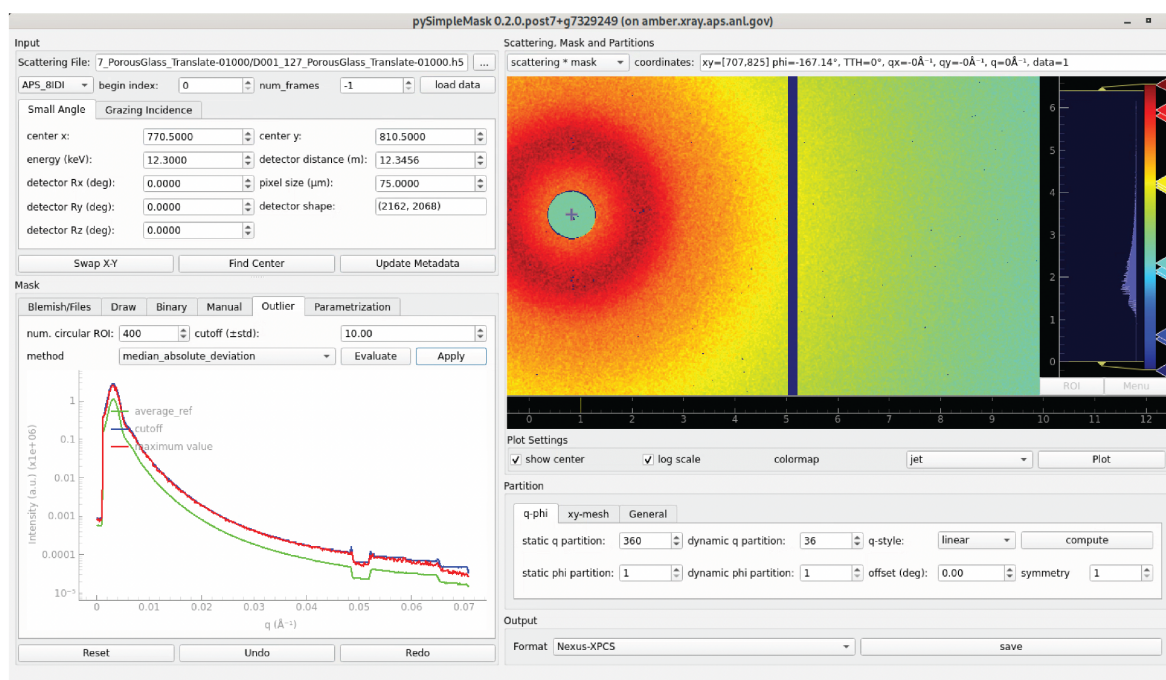
The black arrows indicate the resize/rescale handlers that users can use, while the white arrow indicates the center of the direct beam. ROIs can be moved by pressing the mouse button and dragging the ROI. The exclusive and inclusive ROIs are in solid and dashed lines, respectively.

3. **Binary Thresholding:** Define minimum and maximum intensity values to automatically mask regions outside the defined range.
4. **Manual Editing:** Add specific pixels or regions by inputting coordinates or clicking directly in the GUI. You may also set a radius for intensity-based region growing.
5. **Outlier Detection:** Automatically detect intensity outliers using percentile or Median Absolute Deviation (MAD) metrics.

Before outlier removal



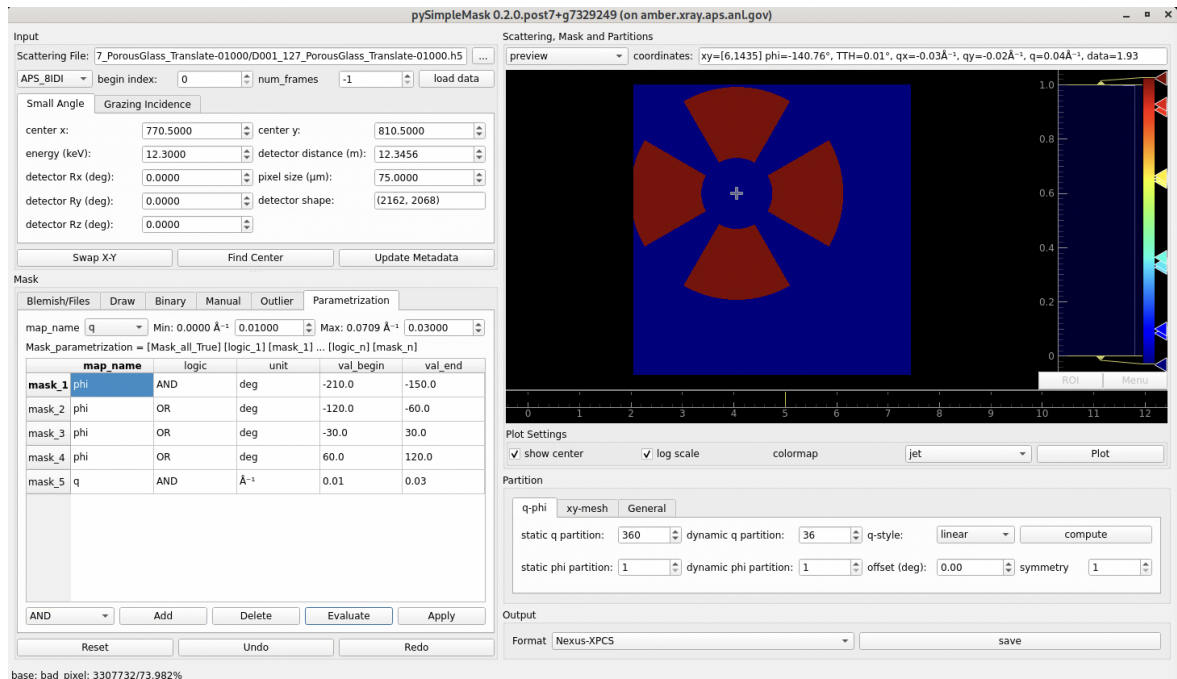
After outlier removal



The figure above illustrates the before and after of outlier detection using MAD. A threshold of 10 is set to mark the pixels whose value is more than 10 MADs away from the median value in the circularly averaged intensity profile. Note, this function is only useful for isotropic scattering data.

6. **Parametrization:** Use default or custom-generated maps to guide masking which allows flexible and precise control over the masking creation:

- **phi:** Polar angle (°)
- **TTH:** 2θ scattering angle (°)
- **q, q_x, q_y:** Momentum transfer (1/Å)
- **x, y:** Detector pixel coordinates



The figure above shows a custom mask created using both **phi** and **q** maps. The default mask being all ones is combined with 4 **phi** constraints that define a 60-degree sector. Then a **q** map constraint is applied to limit the mask to 0.01 to 0.03 Å⁻¹ range. Note the use of logic operator is needed for combining multiple constraints.

Each masking method supports an **Evaluate** → **Apply** workflow. You can preview masks before applying, and undo/redo/reset as needed.

QMap Creation

A QMap groups pixels by spatial position or q-value. Grouped pixels (or "q-bins") are assumed to share similar scattering vectors. This enhances statistical reliability in both static and dynamic analysis.

Steps for QMap creation:

1. Choose two orthogonal axes for binning: - Common choices: (q, phi), (x, y), or (q_x, q_y) - Use General tab for arbitrary combinations
2. Specify the number of bins for: - **Static analysis**: Averaged intensity vs. q - **Dynamic analysis**: Time-resolved correlation
3. Choose binning mode: - Linear or logarithmic (only q supports log scale)
4. Click **Compute** to generate and preview the QMap

Fields saved in a QMap:

- static_roi_map, dynamic_roi_map: 2D integer maps
- static_v_list_dim0, dynamic_v_list_dim1: Value arrays
- static_num_pts, dynamic_num_pts: Bin count tuples
- static_index_mapping, dynamic_index_mapping: Index→value dicts
- mask: Boolean mask array

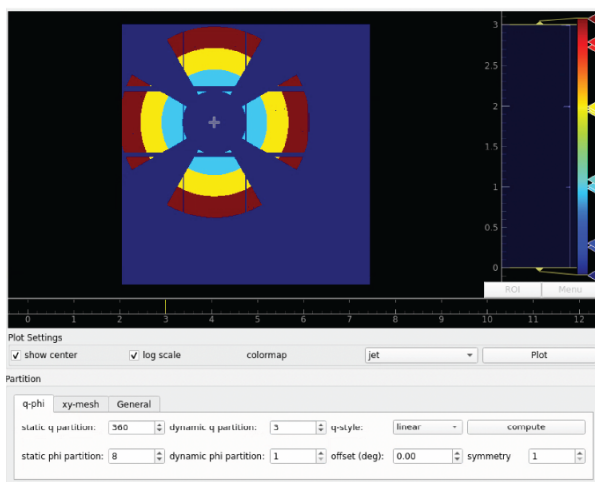
Advanced Features

For scattering patterns with symmetry, QMap generation can incorporate symmetry constraints.

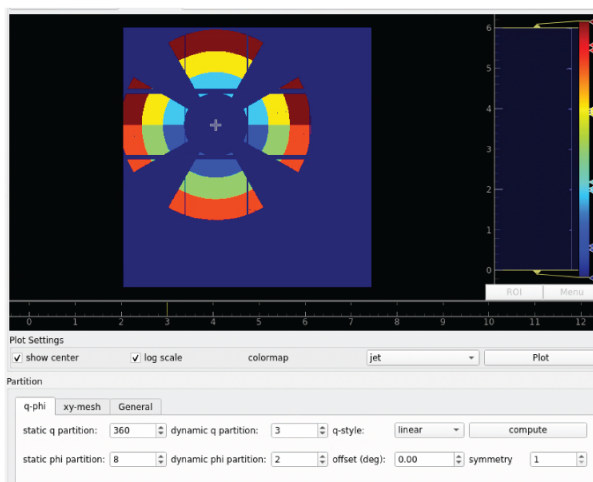
Example: For a sample with horizontal/vertical symmetry, set:

- Symmetry = 2
- Offset = 45° to avoid discontinuities near 0°/360°

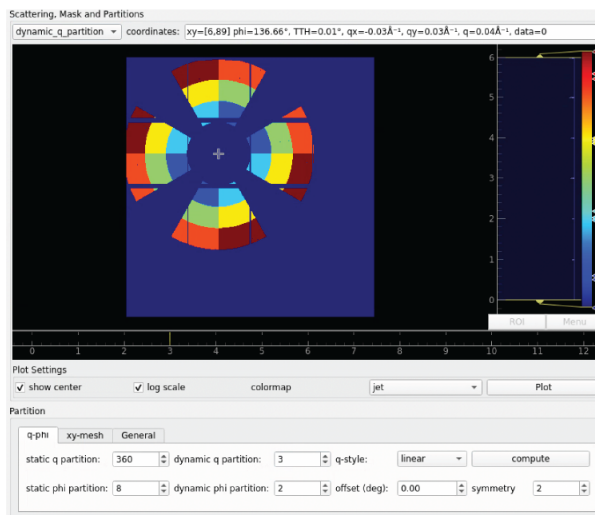
a. q-bin only; no phi-bin



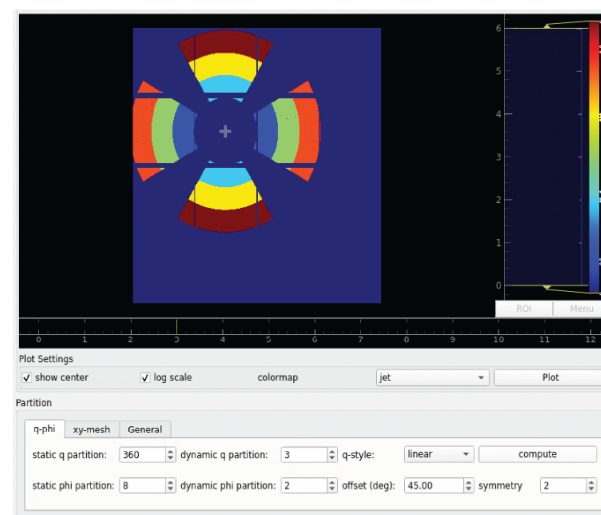
b. q- and phi-bin; symmetry=1



c. q- and phi-bin; symmetry=2, offset=0 deg



d. q- and phi-bin; symmetry=2, offset=45 deg



The figure above illustrates how symmetry constraints can be applied to create a QMap the groups the horizontal/vertical regions as one bin. This is particularly useful when one wants to analyze both regions as a whole to increase the signal-to-noise ratio or to simplify the analysis process. Note, a 45-degree offset is necessary to avoid discontinuities near 0°/360°.

This ensures that symmetric pixel pairs are grouped into the same bin.

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